# 4

# THE BJP'S POLITICAL MOBILISATION OF WELFARE

## 'Labharthees'

'I have been gram pradhan for five years and got about Rs 40 lakh in this time period to spend on the village,' Hemant Chauhan told us, sitting by the ancient Shakumbhari Devi temple near Saharanpur in western UP. 'In comparison to that, we have seen about Rs 2 crore each coming in yearly into the village separately through just two schemes. Personal toilets under Swachh Bharat and money for houses under PM Awaas Yojana-Gramin [PMAY-G].'

Chauhan holds an MBA degree and used to work for Johnson & Johnson as a marketing executive in Lucknow and Dehradun before he decided to move back to the Shahpur Bans Must village in Behat tehsil, near the ancient Shakti Peeth of Shakumbhari Devi, in 2013. Because he was well-educated, the villagers decided to elect him as the pradhan, a position that allowed Chauhan to play a vital role in the management and administration of a plethora of government schemes that touched the life of the village. We were chatting about these schemes in his village in June 2020, discussing whether things were really different under the Modi government as compared to Manmohan Singh's time, when he startled me with the stark comparison on governmental spending in his area.

So, was the size and scale of the welfare money the big political differentiator for the Modi government? Did previous governments not spend similar amounts on these schemes? Indeed, was not the